



What is truly yours

An exercise to separate what you pursue for yourself from what you pursue by inheritance.

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*This guide is a self-knowledge
resource. It does not replace
therapeutic support.*

1. A life full of things you never even chose

Your schedule is full. Your head is full. Your body is full of commitments, goals, projects, ideas, plans for next month, for next year, for the next five years. If someone asked you to list everything you are trying to do at once, the list would be impressive. Alarming, even.

And yet there is a strange sensation. A sensation that does not match the quantity of things you have on your hands. It is a sensation of emptiness. Not total emptiness, not absence. Emptiness in the middle of abundance. Like a room full of objects you do not recognize. Everything is there. But none of it is yours.

Perhaps you know this feeling: you wake in the morning and look at the day that awaits you. Meetings, deliverables, tasks, objectives. And instead of energy, you feel weight. Not the weight of tiredness (although that is there too). The weight of disconnection. As if you were living someone else's life, carrying out a plan someone else drew up for you, pursuing goals that appeared on your list without your remembering having chosen them.

And you continue. Because you know how. Because you are good at what you do. Because everyone tells you that you are incredible, so competent, so capable, so organized, so productive. And you smile. You thank them. And inside, you ask yourself: if I am so good at all of this, why do I feel so far from myself?

I know this woman. I know her because I see her every day in my work. And I know her because I was her for a long time. The woman who pursues. Who runs. Who does not stop. Who has too much talent and too little clarity. Who is brilliant at everything she does except one thing: knowing what is truly hers.

There is a difference between being busy and being oriented. The woman who is oriented also works hard, also gets tired, also has difficult days. But at the end of the day, when she stops, she feels that what she did belongs to her. The woman who is merely busy works just as much or more, but at the end of the day feels strangely empty. As if the effort went somewhere that is not hers. As if the day was spent, not lived.

And there is one signal that never fails: the inability to rest. Not for lack of time. For lack of peace. When the woman who pursues without clarity stops, what appears is not rest. It is anguish. A voice that whispers: "You should be doing something. You should be moving forward.

You should be producing." And that voice does not leave her in peace. So she runs again. Not because she wants to. Because stopping is worse.

And do you know what is most cruel? This woman is not lazy. She is not indecisive. She is not weak. She is, almost always, the strongest person in the room. The one who endures the most. The one who does the most. The one who never complains. And so no one questions her. No one asks her: "Are you sure you want this?" Because who questions the results of someone who produces without stopping? Failures are questioned. Not successes. And she has successes. Many. But none of them taste like her.

If you recognize yourself here, I want to tell you something before we go further: the problem is not lack of effort. It is not lack of talent. It is not lack of discipline. The problem is that a significant part of what you pursue may not be yours. It may be inheritance. It may be comparison. It may be compensation. It may be the attempt to obtain in the future what was missing in the past. And until you see the difference between what is genuinely yours and what is borrowed, the running does not stop. No matter how much you achieve. No matter how hard you try. Thirst does not pass with food. And lack of clarity is not resolved with more effort.

This guide will not give you complete clarity. Complete clarity requires deeper, more accompanied, longer work. But it will give you something that perhaps no one has ever given you: a tool to begin to separate. To look at what you pursue and ask, with honesty: is this mine? Or am I running on someone else's path?

2. Truth, inheritance, comparison, compensation

Everything you pursue has an origin. Every goal on your list, every dream in your head, every objective keeping you up at night, was born somewhere. And that place is not always you.

There are four possible origins for what you pursue. They are not rigid categories. They often overlap. Often one objective is born from two or three origins at once. But distinguishing them is the first step to seeing clearly. Because until you know where what you want comes from, you do not know whether it is genuinely yours.

Truth.

There are things you pursue because they were born in you. They did not come from outside. They did not emerge through comparison. They did not appear to prove anything to anyone. They simply exist inside you, like a seed that was there before any outside influence.

You recognize a true desire by a particular quality: it needs no audience. If no one knew you were pursuing it, you would still pursue it. If no one saw you doing it, you would still do it. There is an expansion in the

body when you think of it. Not urgency, not obligation. Expansion. A wanting that comes from the center and opens, rather than contracts.

True desires are, very often, simpler than we expect. Smaller. Quieter. "I want to write." "I want to learn to really cook." "I want to live in a calmer place." "I want time to read." The mind dismisses them as insignificant. But the body recognizes them immediately. There is a peace in them that does not exist in the others.

Inheritance.

There are things you pursue because someone before you could not have them. Your mother who did not study, and now you accumulate degrees without knowing why. Your father who never had financial stability, and now you work to exhaustion so there is always money in the account. Your grandmother who never left the village, and now you feel a compulsion to travel that seems yours but was born in her frustration.

Inheritance is perhaps the most invisible origin of all. Because it does not arrive in words. No one told you: "Go live my dreams." It arrived in silence. In gazes, in stories told at the dinner table, in sighs, in the

gleam in your mother's eyes when you talked about your plans. She was seeing herself, not you. And you absorbed that as a mandate. Without knowing. Without choosing.

You recognize an inherited desire by a subtle clue: there is weight in it. There is a responsibility that does not match a dream. There is a feeling that if you give up, you are betraying someone. And the person you are "betraying" is not you. It is someone who came before.

Comparison.

There are things you pursue because you saw someone else have them. The colleague who was promoted. The friend who opened a business. The woman you follow on social media who seems to have everything figured out. And suddenly, what she has becomes something you "need" to have too. Not because you wanted it before. But because seeing her have it woke something. An urgency that did not exist five minutes earlier.

Comparison desires are reflections. They are mirrors. They were not born in you. They were born in your reaction to what someone else has or does. And they have an unmistakable quality: the rush. They appear suddenly, urgently, and disappear when attention turns elsewhere. They

are intense and fleeting. And when you pursue them, you do not feel expansion. You feel anxiety. Because you are not walking toward something you want. You are chasing something someone else has.

There is a simple way to test whether a desire is from comparison: imagine that no one, absolutely no one, would ever know you had reached it. Do you still want it? If the answer is "no," or if you feel the interest diminishing, it is probably not yours. It is a reflection. And reflections do not nourish. They exhaust.

Compensation.

There are things you pursue to prove something. To correct something. To erase something. They are not driven by desire. They are driven by pain.

"If I achieve this, I prove I am not what my mother said." "If I get there, no one can call me a failure anymore." "If I have this, my family will have to recognize that I am worth something." Compensation dreams have a different energy from the others. They are furious. Relentless. They accept no rest. The woman who pursues through compensation does not allow herself to stop, because stopping means feeling the original pain. And the original pain is the thing she runs from the most.

You recognize a compensation desire by one thing: the achievement does not calm you. You arrive, you succeed, you reach it, and the satisfaction lasts minutes. Because that was not what you needed. You needed to heal the wound. And no achievement heals wounds. No promotion resolves childhood. No award replaces the gaze that never came.

Compensation desires are the most treacherous because they look like genuine ambition. They look like strength. They look like determination. And they are applauded by society. "Look how strong she is, she came from nothing and reached the top." But inside, the woman who pursues through compensation is exhausted. Not from working. From trying to prove she is worth something. Without ever feeling she has proved it enough.

These four origins, truth, inheritance, comparison, and compensation, are not judgments. None of them is "good" or "bad." Inheritance is not wrong. Comparison does not make you a bad person. Compensation is not weakness. They are human mechanisms, deep, understandable. The problem is not having them. The problem is not seeing them. Because when you do not see them, you pursue everything the same way. You run in all directions at once. And you tire without understanding why.

When you see them, you can choose. And choosing is what makes all the difference.

3. The exercise: list and mark the origin

This is the heart of this guide. This is where we leave words and enter your life.

Before you begin, I want to ask you the same thing I would ask if you were sitting in front of me: go slowly. This may look simple (it is a list, after all). But it is not an intellectual exercise. It is an exercise in truth. And truth, when we finally look it in the face, can touch places we did not expect. So give yourself time. If you need to stop, stop. If you need to come back tomorrow, come back. There is no rush.

You will need paper and pen (or a document on your phone or computer). And you will need honesty. All the honesty you have.

Step 1: The list

Write down everything you are pursuing in your life right now. Everything. Do not filter. Do not judge. Do not organize by importance. Just write.

Include:

- Professional goals (the promotion, the project, the business, the career change, the new course)
- Personal goals (losing weight, exercising, meditating, being more patient, reading more)
- Life dreams (moving to another country, buying a home, having a child, writing a book, traveling)
- Projects in progress (that website you are building, that training you started, that plan you have had for months)
- Behavioral patterns (being the best mother, never failing, having everything under control, pleasing everyone, not needing anyone)

Yes, behavioral patterns count too. Because "being the best mother" is a goal you pursue every day, even if it is not written on any list.

Do not worry about being exhaustive. Start with what comes to mind. You can always come back and add.

Step 2: Mark the origin

Now, for each item on the list, write a letter beside it:

T for Truth (born in you, you feel expansion, it needs no audience) **I** for Inheritance (comes from someone before you, from family, from an un-lived dream of another) **C** for Comparison (born from seeing someone else, it is a reflection, it did not exist before you saw them) **P** for compensation (born from a pain, a lack, the need to prove something)

You can mark more than one letter. There are goals that are part truth and part compensation. There are dreams that began as inheritance and, with time, gained their own truth. You do not need to fit everything into a single label. But start with what dominates. With what you feel is the root.

Let me give you concrete examples, so you understand the kind of honesty this exercise asks for.

Example 1: "I want to be promoted to director." Ask yourself: if no one knew about this promotion, would I still want it? If my mother never mentioned it with pride, would I still pursue it? If there were no title, no public recognition, if it were just more responsibility and more work, would I still want it? If the answer is yes, it may be T. If you feel the promotion serves to prove something (to your father, your family, yourself), it may be P. If you want it because your colleague was pro-

moted and now you feel you have fallen behind, it may be C. If you feel you are fulfilling a career dream your mother could never have, it may be I.

Example 2: "I want to lose 10 kilos." Where does this desire come from? From health? From feeling good in your body? Or from a photo you saw on social media? From a comment your mother made when you were a teenager? From the shame you feel when you compare yourself with other women? If it is about the body and health, it may be T. If it is to match an ideal you absorbed from outside, it may be C. If it is to prove you are not "the fat one in the family," it may be P.

Example 3: "I want to start a business." Did you dream about this before you saw others doing it? Or did the desire appear after reading about successful entrepreneurs? When you think about having your own business, do you feel expansion or anxiety? Is there freedom in this desire or escape? And is there someone in your family who tried and could not, who wanted and never could?

Example 4: "I want to be the best mother possible." Where does this goal come from? From your connection with your children? Or from your childhood, the mother you did not have, the fear of repeating what you lived? Are you taking care of your children or are you trying to correct your own story? If you are correcting it, it is P. If it comes from

loyalty to the model of perfect mother that society imposes on you, it may be C. If it is born genuinely from your relationship with your children, it is T.

Example 5: "I want to own my own home." Is it a genuine desire for stability? Or the repetition of a generation that had no home? If your father grew up without a secure roof and you feel you need property to have peace, it may be I. If everyone around you has bought a home and you feel you are behind, it may be C. If you think about the idea of a home and feel your body calm, it may be T.

Example 6: "I want to change careers." To what? To something that has been calling you for years? Or to something that is fashionable? To something that genuinely makes you curious? Or away from something causing you pain? There is a difference between "I want to go there" and "I want to get away from here." The first may be T. The second may be P in disguise.

Questions that can help you mark each item:

To detect **Truth (T)**: "If I were certain that no one would ever know, would I still want this?" "When I think about this, does my body open or close?" "Did this exist in me before I saw someone else doing it?"

"Can I imagine myself doing this without urgency, without needing a result?"

To detect **Inheritance (I)**: "Did someone in my family want this and could not have it?" "Do I feel that if I give this up, I am disappointing someone?" "Does this goal have to do with my history or with my family's history?" "If I were the first person in my lineage (no parents, no grandparents, no context), would I still want this?"

To detect **Comparison (C)**: "When did I start wanting this? Before or after I saw someone else doing it?" "If I were off social media for six months, would this desire survive?" "Do I want this for myself, or do I want it because someone has it and I do not?" "If that person did not exist, would this goal be on my list?"

To detect **Compensation (P)**: "Am I pursuing this to feel something or to prove something?" "If I reached this and no one acknowledged it, would the pain I feel change?" "Is there a wound beneath this goal? What is it?" "If the pain were healed (magically, without me doing anything), would I still want this?"

Go slowly. Do not force the answers. There are items you will mark immediately. There are others that will ask you for time. There are still others you will leave unmarked, because you still do not know. And that

is all right. Uncertainty is not ignorance. It is honesty.

Step 3: Look at what remains

Now look at your list. Look at the letters.

How many T's do you have? How many I's? How many C's? How many P's?

Not to judge yourself. To see.

Notice what you feel looking at the list. Perhaps astonishment. Perhaps relief. Perhaps sadness. Perhaps a tightening in the chest when you realize that most of your energy goes toward things that are not genuinely yours. All of this is normal. All of this is information.

Now do one thing: imagine you remove from the list everything with I, C, or P. Imagine you set down on the floor the inherited goals, the reflections, the compensations. Imagine you stay with only the T's. What remains?

Perhaps not much remains. Perhaps one or two things. Perhaps, for a moment, you feel panic, because the list became almost empty. And that panic is exactly the point. Because it is there, in that empty space, in

that "almost nothing," that what is genuinely yours lives. And "almost nothing" that is yours is worth more than a list full of borrowed things.

You do not need to make any decisions now. You do not need to let go of anything. You do not need to change anything. The simple act of seeing, of separating, of naming, is already the most important step. Most people go through their entire lives without asking this question. You are asking it. And that is already a great deal.

An important note: if while doing this exercise you touch very deep wounds, memories of neglect, abuse, or trauma, do not stay alone with that. This guide is a starting point, not therapy. Seeking professional help is an act of courage, not weakness.

4. What remains when you let go of the borrowed

If you did the exercise with honesty, you may be looking at your list with a mixture of clarity and vertigo. Clarity because, perhaps for the first time, you can see where what you pursue comes from. Vertigo because what is genuinely yours may seem small. Simple. Almost insignificant, compared to the enormous list of goals you had before.

And this is exactly where the mind panics. Because the mind was trained to measure life in quantity. In goals. In achievements. In production. And when the list shrinks, the mind shouts: "And now? If I am not pursuing all of this, who am I? If I am not running, what do I do? If I have no impressive goals, what do I say when people ask what I do with my life?"

I want to tell you something: that voice is not yours. That voice is fear. The fear of not being enough without the armor of achievements. The fear that, without the resume, without the results, without the list, nothing remains. But something does remain. You remain.

What stays when you let go of the borrowed is not the void. It is the essential. It is what remains when you remove the noise. It is what survives when you turn off the comparison, when you return the inheritance, when you stop compensating. And what survives may have no grand name. It may not fit on a resume. It may impress no one. But when you look at it, you feel something you did not feel with the full list: recognition. Not the recognition of others. Yours. The recognition of something that is yours, that belongs to you, that did not need to be proved or conquered. That simply is.

There is a quality that distinguishes what is genuinely yours from everything else: calm. What is yours does not rush you. It does not shout at you. It does not wake you at three in the morning with anxiety. What is yours waits for you. It is patient. It does not need urgency to exist. It is there, quietly, waiting for you to see it.

And there is another quality: sustenance. What is yours sustains you. When you work on what is genuinely yours, you tire, yes. But it is a different tiredness. It is the tiredness of someone who lived, not of someone who functioned. It is the tiredness that heals with a night's sleep, not the tiredness that no amount of rest resolves. What is yours feeds you. What is borrowed drains you.

I am not saying you have to let go of everything that is I, C, or P. There are inherited goals that, with time, gained their own truth. There are goals that began as comparison and, when questioned, revealed a genuine desire beneath. There are compensations that, once seen, lose their urgency but maintain their interest. The exercise is not to eliminate. It is to see. And when you see, your relationship with the goal changes. Because you are no longer being carried. You are choosing.

The difference between being carried and choosing is the difference between a full life and a life that is yours. You may have exactly the same goals. But if you choose them consciously, the energy is different. The body is different. The result is different. And, above all, the feeling at the end of the day is different.

Keep what is yours. Even if it seems little. Even if it seems simple. Even if the mind says it is not enough. It is. It is more than enough. Because it is true. And truth, however small it may be, fills in a way that no list of borrowed achievements ever did.

5. Bridge to the Infonte

What you did in this guide was a first step. A real, concrete, honest step. You looked at what you pursue and asked: where does this come from? Is it mine?

This question is powerful. And the tool you now have (the list, the four origins, the separation) is something you can return to whenever life accelerates, whenever the schedule fills without you understanding how, whenever the tiredness returns without explanation.

But between seeing and transforming, there is a path. A path that asks for more than a list. That asks for time, presence, guidance. That asks for someone to help you return what is inheritance without guilt, release what is comparison without shame, look at what is compensation with compassion instead of anger.

If this guide made you feel that there is something to change in the way you pursue, the Infonte is the space where that work is done. Not as yet another program of goals and objectives. But as the place where you finally stop pursuing and begin choosing. Where you ask "what is truly mine?" and have silence and company to hear the answer. You will find everything at infonte.viviannedossantos.com.

This guide is the twin of Guide 1, "What is mine, what is not mine." They are the same work seen from two sides. Guide 1 looks at what you carry: the guilt, the pain, the loyalty, the weight that is not yours. This Guide 7 looks at what you pursue: the goals, the dreams, the ambitions that were not born in you. One sets down. The other separates. Both return you to your place.

If you feel that the weight you carry (guilt, invisible loyalty, inherited emotions) is as great as the goals you pursue, the FreeMe is where that crossing is made. The Infonte and the FreeMe are siblings: one works with what you pursue, the other works with what you carry. Both bring you back to yourself. You will find the FreeMe at freeme.viviannedossantos.com.

But for now, stay with what you already have. Return to your list. Look at the letters. And the next time you feel the impulse to run toward the next goal, the next objective, the next proof that you deserve to exist, pause for a moment. Breathe. And ask: "Is this mine? Or am I pursuing someone else's dream?"

You do not need to answer immediately. You do not need to be certain. It is enough to ask the question. Because the question alone already interrupts the automatic. Already creates a space. And in that space, however small it may be, your voice can, finally, be heard.

The list is alive. And so are you.

This guide is a self-knowledge resource based on principles of systemic Family Constellations and on the clinical and personal experience of the author. It does not constitute diagnosis, therapy, or psychological counseling. If you feel you need professional support, please seek a qualified psychologist or psychotherapist.

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